Spring came quietly to the fields north of Silvercreek. Robby was already awake before the sun had fully climbed, checking fences, turning soil, and inspecting the chickens. The earth smelled damp and alive after the first warm rains, and Nina prowled the edges of the fields, tail high, alert to every rustle.

Laura arrived soon after, basket in hand, ready to help. She worked alongside him without fuss, her hands steady, her eyes sharp. They planted seeds in neat rows, swapped small jokes about measurements and tool placement, and laughed at minor mistakes, one row too close, one fencepost slightly crooked, but they kept the rhythm of the work.

By early summer, Robby had mastered the tractor. He could bale hay, repair the worn equipment, and plan routes to avoid eroding soil. Laura joined him in the fields, carrying buckets of water or checking the irrigation lines, her presence calm and encouraging. On hot afternoons, they'd take breaks in the shade of a tree, eating bread and cheese, or leaning against the tractor, casually planning which thing to do next.

Autumn brought the harvest, golden light falling across the crops. Robby helped load produce into wagons bound for Silvercreek, carefully keeping enough for his own plot and livestock. Nina moved like a shadow through the tall stalks, keeping mice and rats at bay, and Robby noted how the cat's satisfaction mirrored his own.

Winter was for indoor work. Robby spent hours repairing old generators, building furniture, and tinkering with small machines. Laura sat nearby, documenting notes, offering advice on wiring, and helping where her hands could reach. They worked in companionable silence, occasionally exchanging smiles over a successful repair or a clever solution. Evenings were spent around the fireplace, planning improvements for the house or farm, quietly talking through the rhythms of the seasons. Steve and Sarah visited from time to time, offering guidance, and testing some of Robby's small inventions.

Through these teen years, the rhythm of life repeated: planting, tending, harvesting, repairing, improving. Mistakes no longer felt disastrous, they were lessons, reminders that every step forward had a cost but also a reward. Robby became known in Silvercreek as someone reliable and capable. Kids looked to him with respect; adults trusted his judgment.

Laura was always there, a steady rock on which Robby built himself up in this new world. Though her father was still very strict about just how far their relationship was allowed to progress, they would steal kisses often and one was rarely seen without the other. Her studies had now migrated to nursing full time along other medical related training to do minor combat medic related tasks.

By the end of each year, as the cold winds returned and the farm rested under frost, Robby could feel the growth of skills, of friendship, and of quiet competence. He was no longer just surviving. He was building, learning, and living in a way that made the world feel like something he could shape, and perhaps, one day, belong to.

By the time Robby turned seventeen, the house was finished. Most of the daily garden tasks and the chickens were moved to the house, and the north fields were now mainly wheat and corn.

The walls were insulated properly, though with sheep wool that he didn't particularly like. He would have preferred rock wool due to its fire resistant nature but obtaining that proved to be impossible at the moment. The roof held through heavy snow and spring storms without a single groan. Solar and wind generation created a surplus most days that fed into the town's power supply. The workshop stood a short distance away, steel frame, reinforced floor, wide doors that could accommodate larger equipment if he ever needed it.

He lived there full time now. No more bouncing between favors, borrowed space, half-finished shelters, or sticks propped up against logs covered in pine boughs. This place didn't just protect him from the weather, it was finally a place he could call home. Everything had a reason for being where it was. Tools were arranged by frequency of use. Workbenches were modular. Shelves were labeled in his precise, utilitarian handwriting.

Steve and Sarah stopped by often. Most of the time just to hang out and talk about events around town, sometimes one or the other had build requests for Robby's workshop which was quickly becoming the go to place to refurbish old things into new working order. Other times it was just to sit, drink honey sweetened hot tea, and talk about the state of Silvercreek. Steve preferred to sit on the porch and pet Nina, while complaining that he didn't like cats. Sarah, predictably, poked at everything electrical, to the point that Robby had her own chalk board hanging on the workshop wall where she could write them down.

The workshop wasn't empty anymore, either. Robby had hired help.

His name was Mark. He was forty-three, broad-shouldered, graying at the temples, and had spent most of his adult life fixing things for people who didn't pay on time. Mark worked steady, asked good questions, and didn't mind taking direction from someone half his age, as long as that someone knew what they were doing.

Robby did.

Mark had laughed the first day. "You sure you're the boss?"

Robby had just handed him a schematic and said, "Yes."

Mark stopped laughing after the third week.

Having an employee changed things. It meant schedules. Payroll. Responsibility. It meant mistakes cost more than time, they cost trust. Robby adapted quickly, learning how to explain his thinking instead of assuming it was obvious, how to double-check work that wasn't his own, how to admit fault when something went wrong.

Word spread.

People from Silvercreek started bringing things by. Broken water pumps. Damaged generators. Old weapons that jammed or misfired too often. Some wanted repairs. Others wanted improvements.

"You made this?" someone would ask, holding a modified tool or reinforced part.

"Yes," Robby would reply.

Sometimes they called him Robby. People who knew him, who remembered him as the quiet kid with the scars.

Others, newer clients, traders passing through, called him Robert. It wasn't a correction he asked for. It just… happened.

Laura still lived with her parents. That hadn't changed, no matter how many evenings she spent at the house helping him organize the workshop or testing tools. Her father made his position very clear, very often.

"You're not eighteen yet," he reminded her. "And he's… not normal."

He didn't say it with cruelty. Just concern. The kind that came from watching a daughter grow up too fast and knowing the world had teeth Robby understood. He didn't like it, but he understood.

Laura's mother, on the other hand, adored him.

"He listens," she told her husband once, not quietly. "And he doesn't posture and preen all day. Do you know how rare that is in boys his age?"

Laura blushed. Her father grunted. The subject changed as it usually did when the subject came up.

Work filled most of Robby's days now. Repairs paid well, but it was the *projects* that kept his attention. One, in particular, occupied a corner of the workshop.

The rifle.

It looked like a pellet gun at first glance, with a compressed air system, reinforced barrel, and custom valve assembly. But the internals were anything but simple. Robby was pushing pressure limits most people didn't even know existed, using layered materials and tolerances so tight they bordered on recklessness.

The goal was clear: performance without gunpowder. Range. Accuracy. Penetration.

On paper, it should have outperformed traditional firearms in controlled conditions. In practice… well, it still wasn't there. Valves failed under sustained pressure. Seals degraded too quickly. One prototype shattered a barrel liner cleanly in half. Robby logged every failure, adjusted, rebuilt, tested again.

He wasn't discouraged. One does not get discouraged when trying to build something new, they simply mark off things that have not yet worked and tackle the problem with different materials or from new angles. Though he was hoping he would figure it out sooner rather than later, supplies of gunpowder and bullets were becoming more difficult to find or make.

At night, when the workshop lights dimmed and Laura headed home after a quick hug and kiss, Robby would sit alone at the workbench, Nina curled nearby having moved into the house with Robby but still visited the farm whenever he went out that way.

His life had weight now. Not the crushing kind, but the kind that anchored you. Work that mattered. People who relied on him. A place that didn't disappear when the season changed.

By the following spring, Robert had finished almost everything the school had to offer, math, science, practical mechanics, and most vocational studies. History, grammar, and the odd social science classes were the only things he still attended, more because the school system required it than any interest of his own. He read the lessons quickly, answered questions carefully, and, when prompted, engaged in discussions with a dry humor that most of the teachers had little appreciation for.

Graduation, when it came, was quiet. There were no speeches about "the future" for him, he had already been living it for years. Ms. Calder handed him a simple hand drawn certificate and shook his hand firmly. "Well done, Robert. You're… ready for the next phase of life." That day for Robert was tough, he spent most of it wondering about his parents.

Summer settled into familiar rhythms. He spent long days at the farm with Laura, driving the tractor, repairing fencing, baling hay, and experimenting with irrigation systems. The sun fell differently on the fields now, he noticed shadows, shifts in soil moisture, and patterns of bird and insect behavior that affected planting. Nina patrolled the edges, sleek and vigilant, occasionally brushing against his legs as if to remind him the world still had rules beyond human ones.

Afternoons and Evenings were for the workshop. Mark had proven to be a reliable worker and often interceded when it came to dealing with customers. Relating with others till something that Robert preferred to avoid whenever possible. A few customers though knew who was really in charge and would bypass Mark when they had particularly difficult projects and go straight to Robert, much to his annoyance.

Laura spent as much time there as her parents allowed. Her hands were deft with tools, and she had a knack for spotting the small errors Robert might miss after hours of repetition. She laughed more freely now, teasing him about minor mistakes, teasing him about his concentration, teasing him about his stubborn pride. Robert didn't blush easily, but with her he felt it anyway. That, perhaps more than anything, had become the measure of his growing adulthood: he could trust someone with his mind, his time, his attention.

Silvercreek itself had become a second chance. People knew him not just as Robert the boy who survived, but as Robert the craftsman, Robert the engineer. More repairs came in steadily: generators, water pumps, doors, weapons, even small experimental devices that required careful calibration. He measured risks, calculated tolerances, and delivered results. Mistakes still happened, sometimes costly, sometimes frustrating, but he no longer feared them the way he had as a child. Consequences were part of life, and he met them with preparation, not panic.

Shipwork continued in parallel. Weekly trips to the shipyard reminded him that the city, the fort, and the world beyond weren't abstractions, they were places where responsibility meant something tangible. He learned the rhythm of team coordination, the importance of documentation, and the delicate balance between innovation and safety.

And still, through all of it, Laura remained beside him. Not always physically, she had her own lessons, her own chores, her own responsibilities, but always present in gestures, shared routines, and the quiet language they had developed: a glance over a blueprint, a gentle hand, a smile passed across a table while testing machinery.

The growth was not flashy. It did not come with fireworks or proclamations. It came in the steady hum of the tractor, the squeak of hinges, the smell of timber and oil, and the laughter that followed him through the fields when Laura was near.

By the end of that year, Robert was ready, not just to take his place in Silvercreek, or to work on the first ship, or to continue the projects he loved, but to step into the world with a quiet confidence that was earned, and entirely his own.